# SOP — Daily Inbox Triage

| | |
|---|---|
| PURPOSE | Clear the inbox to zero once a day, and make sure nothing that needs an answer is left waiting on memory. |
| SCOPE | The shared client inbox: Gmail, all mail arriving in the INBOX label. |
| OWNER | Alvin Moncada |
| APPLIES TO | Anyone covering the inbox, including a stand-in. |
| VERSION | 1.1 |
| REVIEW | Monthly, first working day |
| TIME REQUIRED | 15 minutes, once per day, morning |

## 1. BEFORE YOU START

- The seven labels exist: `01-Action` `02-Waiting` `03-Clients` `04-Finance` `05-Admin` `06-Reference` `07-Archive`
- The eight filters are active.
- You have the client's escalation contact and their working hours in front of you.

## 2. THE RULES THAT MAKE THIS WORK

**One touch.** An email is opened once and decided once. Opening the same message on three mornings is the actual cost of a messy inbox, not the message itself.

**Two minutes.** If the reply takes less than two minutes, write it now. If it takes longer, it becomes a task, not an inbox item.

## 3. THE FIVE DECISIONS

Work top to bottom. The first match wins.

| # | IF THE EMAIL… | THEN | LABEL |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | needs an answer or decision from me today | reply now, or add to today's task list with a time | `01-Action` |
| 2 | needs someone else (client, supplier, teammate) | forward or ask, note the date you expect a reply | `02-Waiting` |
| 3 | is automated, a notification, or bulk mail | read the subject only, then archive unless it needs today | `06-Reference` |
| 4 | is money: invoice, receipt, statement, payment | file it, flag anything overdue to the client same day | `04-Finance` |
| 5 | is done, or no longer needs a reply | archive. Do not leave it in the inbox "to be safe" | `07-Archive` |

> Two things this table deliberately does not allow: no "*later*" label — a message is either work for today, waiting on someone, or finished; and no reading for information during triage — anything worth reading properly goes to `06-Reference` and gets read at a set time.

## 4. THE 15 MINUTES

| | |
|---|---|
| **Minutes 0–2**<br>**Scan** | Do not open. Sort by sender and subject. Anything the filters caught is already out. Note how many messages are actually left. |
| **Minutes 2–10**<br>**Work the decisions** | Newest first is wrong; work oldest first so nothing ages out. Apply rule 1 or 2 only; every reply you write here is short by design. |
| **Minutes 10–13**<br>**Chase list** | Open `02-Waiting`. Any item whose expected date has passed gets a short follow-up today, using the follow-up template. |
| **Minutes 13–15**<br>**Close out** | The INBOX is empty. `01-Action` holds the items you will finish today. Say the number out loud or note it: *"four action, none waiting, inbox zero."* That number is the record. |

## 5. WHAT "DONE" LOOKS LIKE

☐ INBOX is empty; `01-Action` holds only what you will finish today.

☐ Every `02-Waiting` row has a date in its subject or a note in the task list.

☐ `04-Finance` contains every invoice received today, including the ones that arrived before you started.

☐ Zero unread in `01-Action` at the end of the day.

## 6. EXCEPTIONS

| SITUATION | WHAT TO DO |
|---|---|
| **A message needs a decision you are not authorised to make** | Label `01-Action`, message the client with the question and the options, note the deadline. |
| **A client emails after hours with something urgent** | Answer only if the retainer says so; otherwise reply at start of business with the acknowledgment template. |
| **A message is clearly phishing or a spoofed sender** | Do not click; report to the client's IT contact; label `05-Admin`; never `01-Action`. |
| **Two people are answering the same thread** | Leave a short internal note ("Alvin handling, reply by Thu"), stop replying yourself. |
| **You will miss the daily triage** | Tell the client before the day ends, not after. The SOP survives one skipped day; it does not survive a silent one. |

## 7. HANDOVER

Everything needed to cover this inbox is in three files: this SOP, the setup sheet, and the templates. No task lives only in my head, and no rule exists that is not written here. If a rule changes, this document changes the same day — an SOP that lags reality teaches the next person the wrong thing.

## REVISION HISTORY

**1.1** · 2026-10-27 — Definition of done corrected after the first full inbox-zero run: INBOX is empty and `01-Action` holds today's items.

**1.0** · 2026-10 — First version, written after the first sandbox triage run.